



A TIGER IN THE ZOO

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Leslie Norris

About the Author:

Leslie Norris (1921-2006) was a Welsh poet, short story writer, and teacher. He is known for his clear, vivid, and realistic poetry that often deals with nature, animals, and human emotions. Norris spent much of his life observing the natural world and animals. In *A Tiger in the Zoo*, he powerfully contrasts the tiger's natural wild life with its caged existence, highlighting themes of freedom and captivity.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- Freedom versus captivity.
- The cruelty of confining wild animals in zoos.
- The contrast between a tiger's natural majestic life and its imprisoned condition.
- Suppression of natural instincts.
- Sympathy for wild animals kept in unnatural environments.

Values:

- Respect for wild animals and their natural habitats.
- Importance of freedom for all living beings.
- Compassion towards caged animals.
- Awareness about animal rights and wildlife conservation.
- Criticism of human dominance over nature.

2. Summary

A Tiger in the Zoo is a powerful poem that presents the miserable condition of a tiger locked inside a small cage in a zoo. The poet contrasts this helpless caged life with the tiger's natural life in the jungle, where he would be free, majestic, strong, and fearless.

Inside the cage, the tiger moves only a few steps because the space is extremely limited. His bright stripes and soft padded feet make him look beautiful, but his silence is not peace - it is suppressed anger and frustration. The phrase quiet rage shows that the tiger is burning with helpless fury because his freedom has been taken away.

The poet then imagines the tiger in his natural surroundings. In the wild, he would move near the jungle's edge, frighten the village, and show his real strength through his teeth, claws, and fearless movement. This image shows what the tiger was meant to be: a powerful ruler of the forest, not a trapped object for human entertainment.

The reality is painful. The tiger is locked in a concrete cell, and his great strength is useless behind bars. Visitors come to watch him, but he ignores them because he has lost interest in the artificial world around him. His body is alive, but his natural spirit has been imprisoned.

At night, when the zoo becomes quiet, the tiger listens to the last sounds of human activity and looks at the bright stars. His shining eyes suggest longing, sadness, and perhaps memories of freedom. The stars also remind us that the sky is free, while the tiger is not.

3. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1:

The tiger moves slowly inside the narrow cage. His vivid stripes are visible, and his soft padded feet make his movement silent. But this silence hides deep frustration. He is calm on the outside but angry inside because he has been denied freedom.

Stanza 2:

The poet imagines the tiger in the jungle, where he should be free. There he would move near village houses at the forest edge, display his natural weapons, and create fear. This stanza presents the tiger's real power and majesty in the wild.

Stanza 3:

The tiger is not in the jungle; he is trapped in a concrete cage. His physical power is wasted behind iron bars. He walks up and down the cage and ignores the visitors, showing his sadness, anger, and rejection of captivity.

Stanza 4:

At night, the tiger hears the final sounds of the zoo and stares at the stars. His brilliant eyes reflect longing for freedom. The contrast between the open sky and the closed cage makes his captivity feel even more painful.

4. Literary Devices

- Alliteration: Repetition of consonant sounds, such as in phrases describing quiet movement and rage.
- Imagery: Strong visual imagery of the tiger's stripes, claws, fangs, cage, eyes, and stars.

- Contrast: The poem continuously contrasts the tiger's free jungle life with his caged zoo life.
- Personification: The tiger is shown with human-like emotions such as anger, sorrow, and rejection.
- Rhyme Scheme: ABBA in each stanza.
- Enjambment: Some sentences continue from one line to the next, creating flow and emphasis.
- Symbolism: The tiger symbolises all wild animals trapped by humans and denied their natural freedom.

The poem evokes deep sympathy for the tiger and criticises the practice of keeping wild animals in cages for human entertainment.

5. Moral (in points)

- Wild animals should live freely in their natural habitats, not in cages.
- Captivity suppresses the natural beauty, strength, and instincts of animals.
- We must show compassion towards animals and support wildlife conservation.
- Freedom is the most precious gift for every living creature.
- Humans should not imprison animals for pleasure, display, or entertainment.
- The true majesty of a tiger or any wild animal can only be seen in the wild.
- Small acts like visiting zoos can indirectly support animal suffering when animals are kept in poor conditions.
- We should protect forests and natural environments so animals can live freely.

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